

Fearing ‘a real gaping hole in the safety net’

Tighter restrictions coming to SNAP

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Growing up with a single mother who had a disability, Angela Burke has vivid childhood memories of how much food stamps made a difference at their dining room table.

“When you got those benefits, you were eating like kings. We really weren’t — it was more like tuna casserole — but we thought it was wonderful,” she said. “Then you had to make that food last throughout the month. We had to be very careful, and that was something that I think really made an impression on me.”

The record-breaking government shutdown, which has interrupted food

benefits under the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program, known as SNAP, has left many local families hungry and lacking resources.

That hardship may be an early sign of what’s to come, experts said, albeit on a smaller scale. Several changes to SNAP under President Trump’s signature tax and spending legislation are expected to make it more challenging for some Americans to get food assistance. One change, for example, requires most able-bodied adults to work at least 80 hours a month to receive benefits for longer than three months, while another change bans non-citizens from the benefits.

The Congressional Budget Office, a nonpartisan federal agency that provides budgetary analysis of proposed legislation, estimates that SNAP’s new work re-

SNAP, Page A7



HIROKO MASUIKE/NEW YORK TIMES

One potential change to SNAP, pushed by Robert F. Kennedy Jr., would be to ban sugary foods and drinks.

Federal government little help as Maine battles HIV outbreak



BEN PENNINGTON FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

People in need browsed through free donated clothes at the Storehouse inside the Brick Church in Bangor.

With support on hold during shutdown, homeless bear the brunt

By Jason Laughlin
GLOBE STAFF

BANGOR — Steven Cronk, 41, sleeps among a row of tattered, sun-bleached tents that cling to a small strip of land between this city’s rusting railroad tracks and the Penobscot River. He estimated that most of the roughly five dozen people in this homeless encampment have HIV.

Cronk is among them. He is certain he was infected through a dirty needle and is still reeling from the diagnosis he received about a year ago.

“Some days I think I’ve got a handle on it, some days it just goes downhill,” said Cronk, who has spent much of his life homeless.

Penobscot County, which typically sees two new HIV cases a year, has reported 30 new infections since October 2023 — the biggest outbreak in state history. At the end of September, Maine public health experts asked for support from the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, citing a “significant public health concern,” according to state documents requested by the Globe.

But after initially approving the request, the CDC put it on hold on Oct. 9. Travel isn’t authorized during the government shutdown, said Emily Hilliard, a spokesperson for the Department of Health and Human Services, which oversees the CDC, in response to a re-

HIV, Page A10

Nursing home chain could dodge multitude of claims

By Kay Lazar
GLOBE STAFF

Diana Coleman died of a stroke last year. But up until her last breath, the 73-year-old Townsend woman was battling Genesis Health-Care, a massive nursing home company, over the death of Coleman’s mother, Viola Whittemore, who died in 2020 after falling in one of Genesis’ Massachusetts nursing homes.

Now, Coleman’s 43-year-old daughter, Jillian Allen, is carrying the family’s lawsuit forward. But it will be more challenging than Allen had ever imagined.

That’s because Genesis, a troubled nursing home chain with 49 such facilities across New England and a history of violations and low ratings, is in bankruptcy court, planning to sell the chain next Tuesday — to itself.

The complex action, if approved by a judge in the Texas bankruptcy proceedings, would wipe out much of the liability claims against the company.

Several members of New England’s congressional delegation, including Massachusetts Senator Elizabeth Warren, are crying foul, saying the proceedings will stiff plaintiffs with pending neg-

ligence and wrongful death suits, like the Coleman family, as well as endanger a pension fund for roughly 500 of its workers in Connecticut, and leave many more medical supply, pharmacy, and other vendors in a lurch.

The move also raises questions about the quality of care for the thousands of residents who remain patients in Genesis’ nearly 200 nursing homes nationwide.

“My mother worked really hard to get justice for my grandmother, and I want to honor that and follow through with the case,” said Allen.

NURSING HOMES, Page A10

Senate deal may alter Democrats’ road ahead

Anger in party as shutdown nears end could be a blow to Schumer’s leadership

By Sam Brodey
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — The federal government shutdown, the longest in history at 43 days, could finally come to an end this week.

But for Democrats, the drama may just be getting started.

Backlash within the party over the emerging deal to end the shutdown could worsen Senate minority leader Chuck Schumer’s long-term standing as caucus leader and fuel an ongoing battle among Democrats over whom their leaders should be and how they should counter President Trump.

Eight Democratic senators voted for the deal Sunday, despite it not satisfying their demand to fully fund Affordable Care Act subsidies set to expire soon. The outrage was near-instantaneous not just on social media or from liberal groups, but also from Democrats running as antiestablishment candidates in 2026 who have found the shutdown, and Schumer’s handling of it, to be a powerful foil for their own races.

Schumer voted no on the proposal, but many Democrats believe he failed to keep the caucus together to win a battle they felt could be won.

Chief among them may be Representative Seth Moulton, of Salem, who is running against Senator Ed Markey, of Malden, in the Democratic primary. Markey voted no on the shutdown deal, torching it as a “massive mistake” in a statement and encouraging people to “turn our anger into action and let it fuel us for the long fight ahead.”

Moulton, who said at the beginning of his

SCHUMER, Page A7

SHUTDOWN DAY 43

Sept. 19
Date of last House session

594,048
Workers furloughed

35 days
Previous longest shutdown

Blue Cross, UMass dispute is a sign of times in health care

By Jessica Bartlett
GLOBE STAFF

For Sarah Reilly, the letter she received from Blue Cross Blue Shield of Massachusetts was alarming: she could lose access to her doctors by Jan. 1 because of a contract dispute between her health insurer and the UMass Memorial Health system.

Reilly, 32, of Whitinsville, had come to rely on those UMass-affiliated physicians, for navigating everything from her life-threatening complications during pregnancy to her daughter’s heart condition.

“Maintaining your care with your doctors who know your care intimately, it’s not just a convenience — for me, it’s a lifeline,” Reilly said, adding: “The idea of starting over is stressful and terrifying.”

The contract dispute between the state’s largest health insurer and the largest medical provider in Central Massachusetts also involves two of the most intractable problems in health care — the seemingly unsustainable cost, and the acute shortage of primary care doctors. And for one side to prevail, the other will likely have to give up something, in a confrontation where regardless of how it all shakes out, patients likely won’t be happy.

UMass has said that without increased rates, it

BLUE CROSS, Page A6



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

Sarah Reilly and her family are faced with having to find a new team of doctors.

BostonGlobe.com

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\$4.00



Airlines canceled dozens more flights at Logan Airport and experts warned it may take time to recalibrate the nation’s system when the shutdown finally ends. **B1.**

Massachusetts hospitals, which experienced an acute shortage of nurses during the pandemic, have made significant progress filling vacancies, according to a report. **B5.**

Britain’s government rallied to the defense of the BBC after allegations of bias from critics and the threat of a lawsuit from President Trump about the editing of a speech. **A3.**

Shortcuts save time when you’re preparing Thanksgiving dinner, but the results aren’t always exactly great. Devra First puts some well-known products to the taste test. **G1.**

Flake out

Wednesday: Early flurries. High 43-48. Low 37-42.

Thursday: A bit warmer. High 48-53. Low 33-38.

High tide: 4:35 a.m., 4:49 p.m.

Sunrise: 6:31 Sunset: 4:25

Weather and Comics, G6-7.